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A Glimpse of the Propagation of Islamic Teachings during Muharram (Reports from the Secretaries of the England and East Pakistan Chapters of Idara Ma'arif-e-Islam)

England Chapter report (Birmingham, England)

To the respected President of Idara Ma'arif-e-Islam, Central Office, Lahore, Pakistan.

13 Muharram-ul-Haram 1961 / 27 June 1961

Salam Alaykum and greetings of Ya Ali Madad. I hope you are all well.

This year in Birmingham, and perhaps for the first time in all of Britain, regular Muharram-ul-Haram gatherings (Majalis) were held and mourning (Matam) was performed. Mr. Hafiz Ali Muhammad Sahib, who is a man of faith and a Hafiz of the Quran, placed his hall at the disposal of "Idara Ma'arif-e-Islam" for the Muharram gatherings. It is a very spacious place; thousands of people can be accommodated. Since our organization is still new and the environment here is quite busy, it is difficult to gather everyone together. However, I am immensely grateful to the Almighty that upon my request, I contacted every believer I could find, either by visiting them personally, calling them, or writing letters. Everyone expressed enthusiasm. Even when I suspected someone might be a believer, I asked them directly, and in the end, sixty percent turned out to be believers. Some people took offense, but I continued my mission. After all, gathering a few sincere believers holds significance. I found the names and addresses of 65 Sadat and believers here, of whom over forty turned out to be staunch believers and participated in our gatherings. All the Majalis of Ashra-e-Muharram were held regularly. After the fifth of Muharram, Matam was also performed at the conclusion of the Majalis. I was initially hesitant, wondering if these people would like it or not. I did not have full knowledge of the beliefs of the respected Hafiz Ali Muhammad Sahib. I thought he was of the *Tafzili* (pro-Caliphate) type, but upon performing Matam, I realized he was eager to perform Matam himself. 18 or 20 young men turned out to be very good mourners. They were from different regions, and their styles of Matam were different. However, two sincere young men, Nazir Hussain and Fida Hussain, who have been touring England since last August with the party of the famous artist Muhammad Alam, participated in our Majalis daily and recited elegies (Marsiyas) with great melody. Nazir Hussain and Fida Hussain are high-quality Noha reciters and mourners. After a short time, our mourning party became organized, and Matam continued for a long time after the Majlis.

On the night of Ashura, six or seven young men came specifically from a city called Rugby, 70 or 80 miles away from Birmingham, and Matam continued almost all night. At dawn, I gave the Adhan in a loud voice, and people formed rows and prayed together. I recited the prayer in a loud voice, and everyone else made their intention (Niyyat) individually but joined me in prayer (please write your guidance on whether this is correct). Then the Majlis started at 9 AM and ended at approximately 11 AM. Then, on that same day, i.e., the day of Ashura, from 7 PM to 10 PM, a Sham-e-Ghariban Majlis was held at the residence of Hafiz Ali Muhammad Sahib. In every Majlis, some believer would bring *Niaz* (food offering), which was distributed as *Tabarruk* after the Majlis. Last Monday night, a Majlis was held again in the same Triangle Hall where the

Muharram Majalis were held. On the night of the tenth, a Syed Manzoor Hussain Shah, a resident of Dhudial, District Mirpur, currently in Birmingham, who had joined the Zakireen, also recited the Sham-e-Ghariban Majlis. It is hoped that the Chehlum will also be observed here in a better manner than before.

The local weekly newspapers have written about these Majalis. We are being talked about all over Britain. It is hoped that many other believers whom we do not yet know will also join Idara Ma'arif-e-Islam. At present, I am working as the Secretary. Hafiz Ali Muhammad Sahib is the President, and Chaudhry Rashid Ahmed Sahib is the Vice President. Captain Ali Sher Hussain Shah Sahib, Syed Mastan Shah Sahib, Syed Khalil Shah, Ghulam Mustafa Rabbani Karbalai, Mistri Fazal Karim, and other gentlemen are very ACTIVE workers. Dear Sajjad Haider and Nazar Baqir participated in every Majlis and were a source of comfort and strength for me. Please publish this information in Ma'arif-e-Islam and other national journals as appropriate. After every Majlis, I recite the Ziyarat in a loud voice as per tradition; my voice has become very loud. I have also delivered speeches in the Majalis by taking ideas from your articles. I am sending the complete list of members here separately.

Wa salam.

(M.H. Shah) Syed Manzoor Hussain Shah, Secretary, Idara Ma'arif-e-Islam (England Chapter)

East Pakistan Chapter report

Report of the Secretary, East Pakistan Circle, Tejgaon, DLR, June 17, Evening

Respected and Honoured General Secretary, Idara-e-Maarif-e-Islam, Central Office.

Peace be upon you. I hope that by the grace of the Infallible Imams, you are in good health. The necessary request is that this year, during the month of Muharram, as per previous custom, the fourth book of Idara-e-Maarif-e-Islam, "*Aqaid-e-Shia*" (*Shia Beliefs*), was distributed free of charge in gatherings, as well as in all mosques and madrasas of Dhaka, and among the public in every neighbourhood. This booklet, which has been written in the Bengali language, sheds light on the beliefs, Usul al-Din (Principles of Religion), and Furu al-Din (Branches of Religion) of the Jafari community.

The misunderstandings that had persisted among the public for a long time, due to which the public was averse to the Shias, have been removed, and they have been informed about the meaning and significance of Shi'ism. Along with this, the dates of birth and martyrdom of the Fourteen Infallibles, as well as the scholars, believers, and Imams of the Ahl al-Sunnah wal-Jama'ah who lived during their times, have been recorded.

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In East Pakistan, the atmosphere is one of mutual cooperation and goodwill. People meet one another with sincerity, and there is a strong desire for unity and collective progress. The community here is striving to strengthen its social and religious life, and there is a growing awareness of the importance of education and organisation. If this spirit continues, then, God willing, the future will be even brighter. It is essential that we maintain harmony among ourselves and work together for the advancement of our community.

Syed Isa Mustafa, Secretary, East Pakistan